Case Study

Relaunching a Fashion Brand Experience on Web

Pedro Björn
Staff Designer leading Web UX

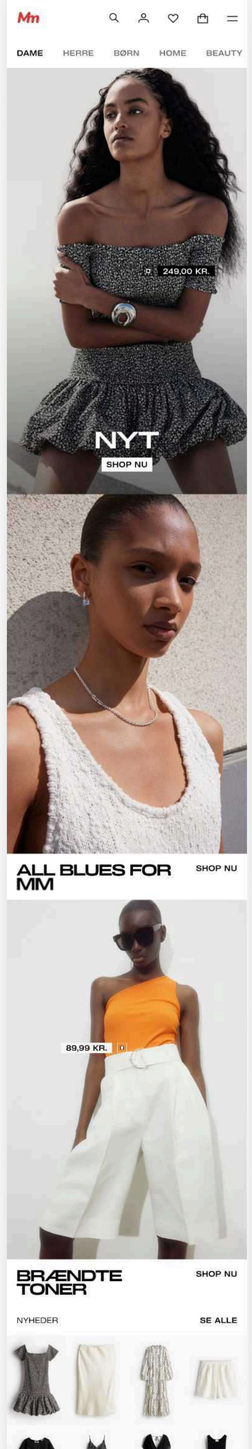
Overview

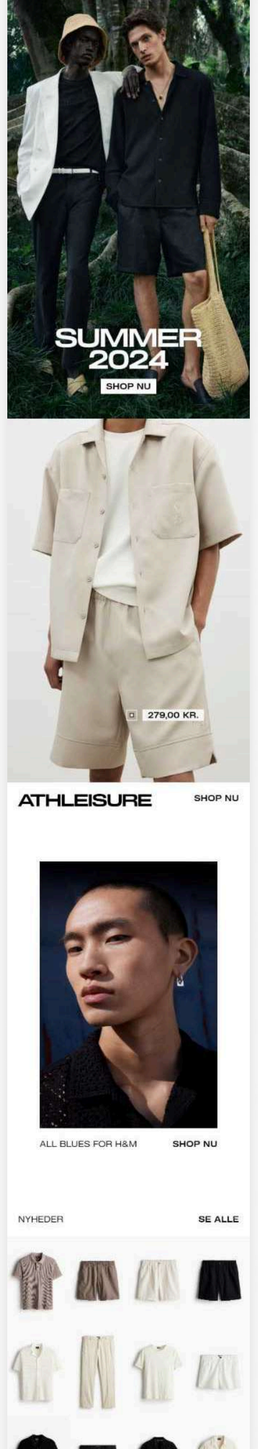
Context

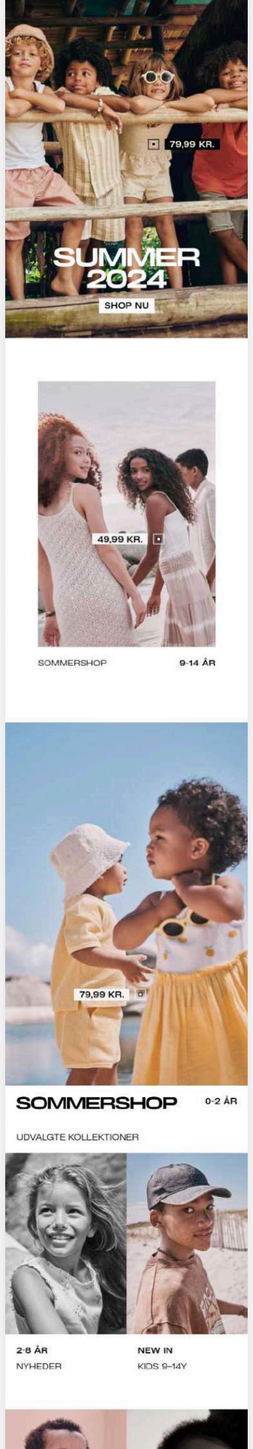
Process

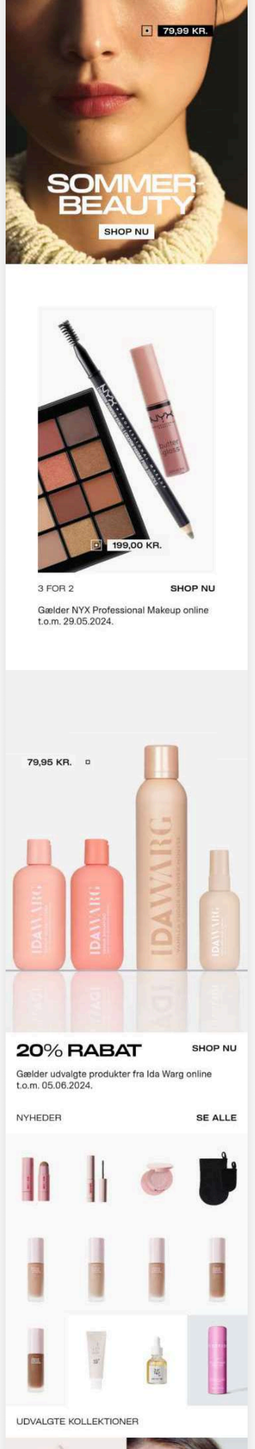
Deep-Dive: *Entrances*

Conclusion









Summary

Goal
Redesign the UI visual identity to uplift our products while also improving the Landing Page sessions and reduce exit rates.

Summary

- **Increase of Sessions, a drop in Single-Page-Sessions and Exit Rate** ensured an increase of up to ~20k customers per month for two markets would continue down the funnel towards transaction.

- **Web experience and SEO was improved by 40%** thanks to consolidation of department pages and reduction in page loading times, largely thanks to less content on the Index and Department pages.



Context

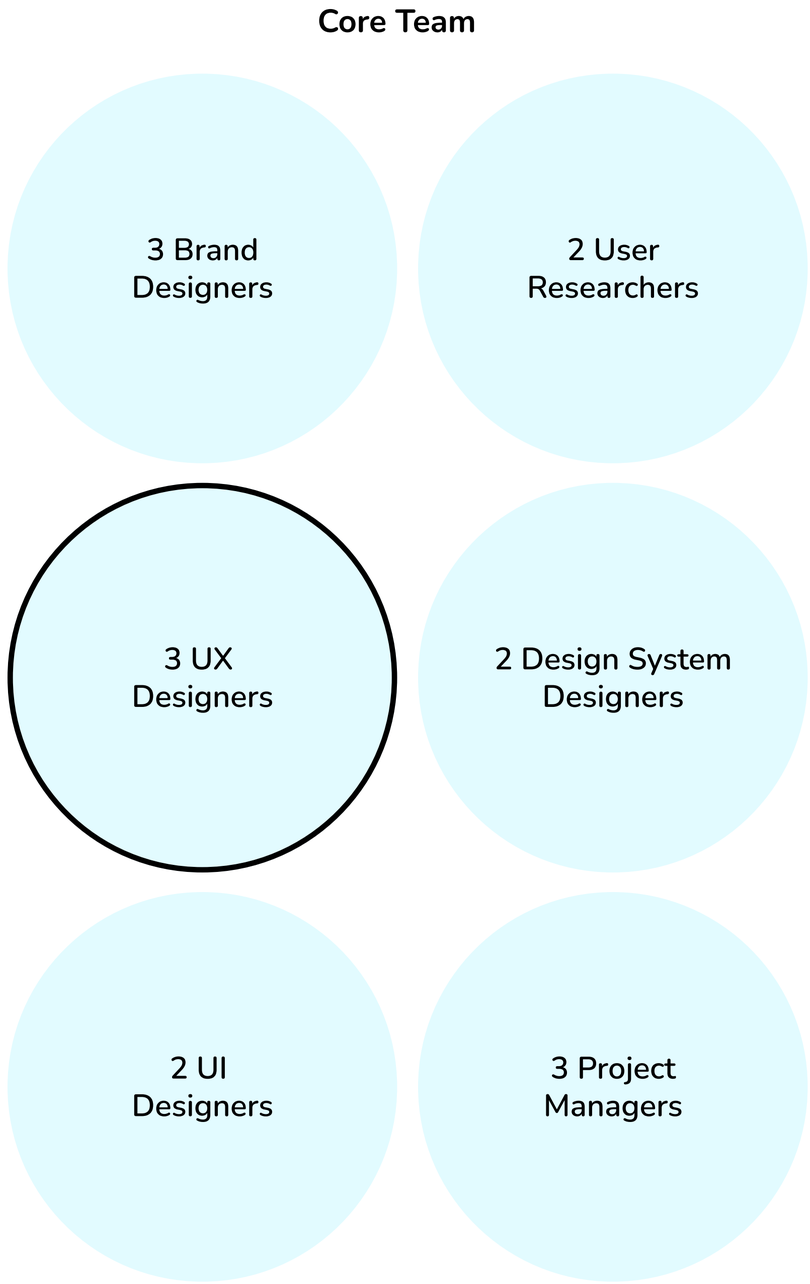
Team Composition & Role

Project Overview & Goals

Team Composition & Role

For this project a **Core Team** was created, which included a combination of seniors from different parts of the organisation.

My role was **Lead Web User Experience of the Gobal rebrand**, responsible for ensuring the brand lift met the standards for Web.



⚠️ *Looking back, we were too centralised and water-fall, with not enough room for contribution from teams or developers.*

Problem Statement

Mm's brand recognition, sales and customer retention are dropping. This is due to that we are no longer considered a Fashion brand, but a retail brand.

Vision
Re-establish ourselves as a fashion brand and focus on quality.

Mission
Rebrand the digital and physical experience to regain our fashion credibility.



The Customer

Mm wants to recapture the influential Fashionista, a young (18-34) fashion ambitious customer that knows what they like, are open to expanding their style and want to share and be shared with.

The hypothesis is that if we bring in the Fashionista, the regular customer, influenced by these trend setters, will follow and invest more in quality, stylish apparel.



Goals

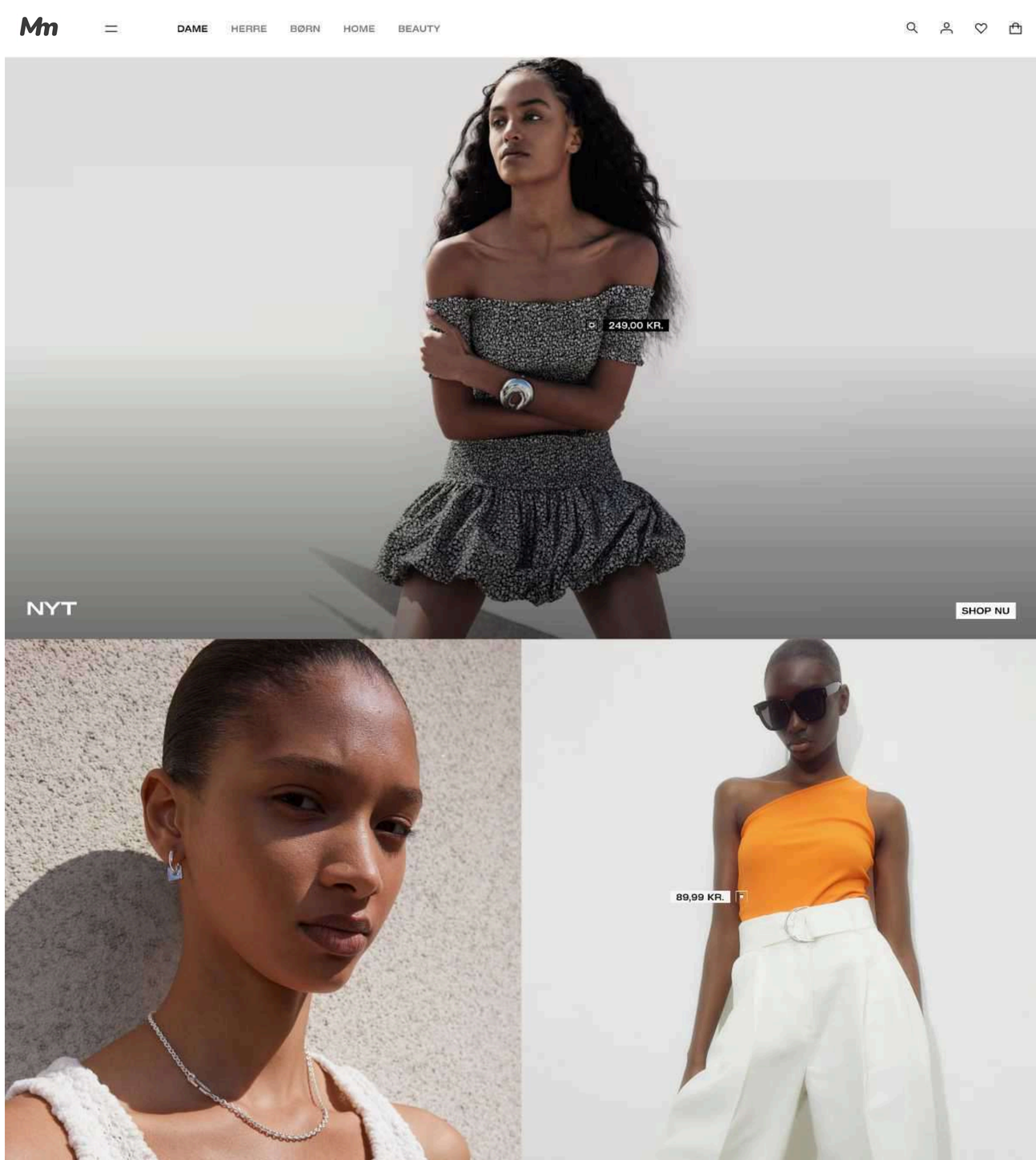
- Lift the fashion & brand on App & Web.
- Unify the experience through Branding, Content, UI and UX.
- Declutter and focus.

Scope

2 Markets as pilot. Global later.

Timeframe

9 months



Process

Planning & Strategy

Exploration & Vision

Design Guidance

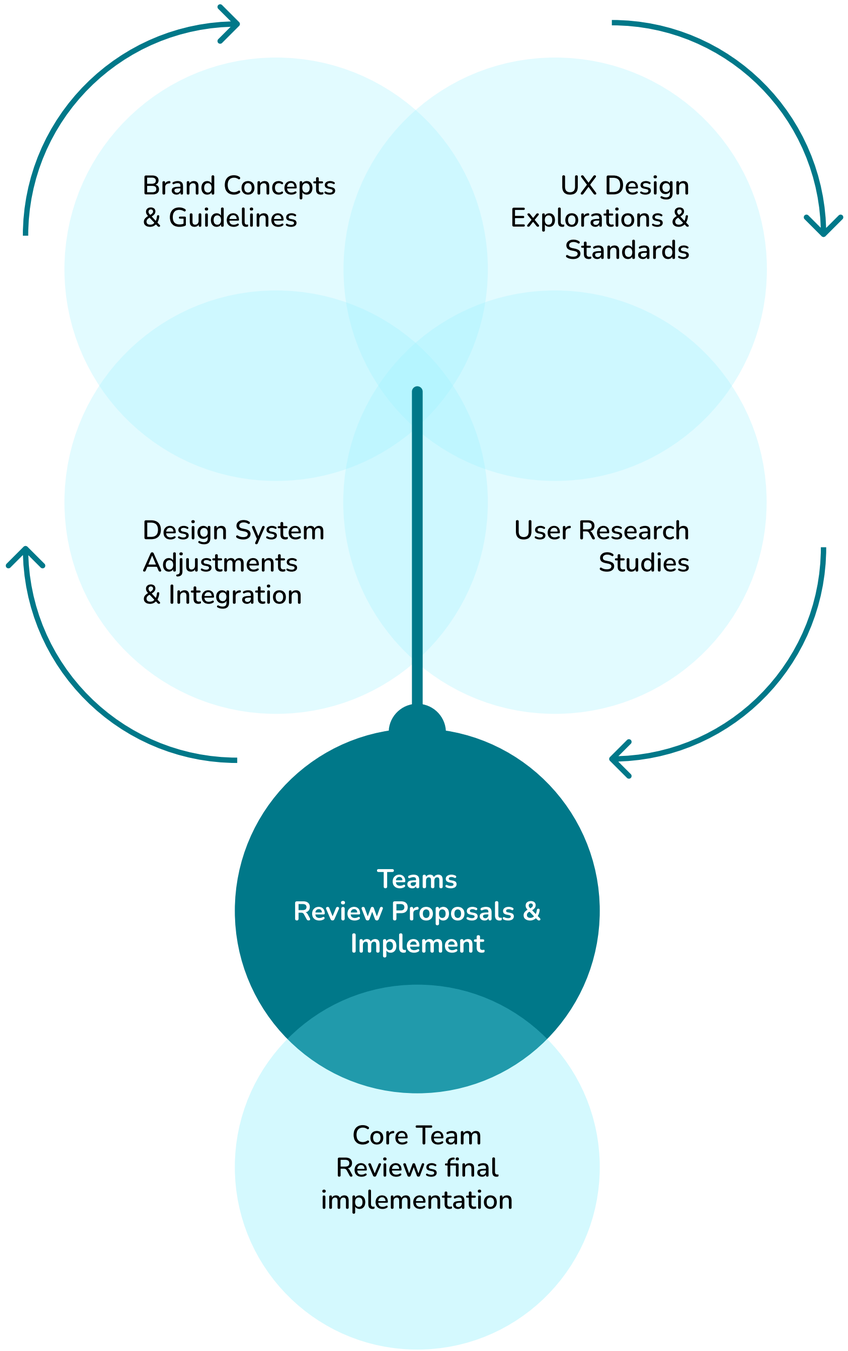
Collaboration & Design QA

Process

Planning & Strategy

I proposed a more cyclical workflow where the **Core Team Brand, UX and DS would jointly create concepts** for each core views and patterns that **teams would then use as a reference** for all subsequent views and patterns.

Concept creation would be a cyclical process where teams would co-create and review the concepts.



Process

Exploration & Vision

We UX Designers in the Core Team took insights and Shopping Journey set by our Customer Experience team, got together and facilitated workshops to explore opportunities.

We then mapped these along a Customer Journey that we used to connect to insights as we proceeded.

🖐 *Aside from preparing and co-facilitating the Workshops, I also conceptualised how these ideas would translate on Web, while the other two designers focused on App.*



Mapping known opportunities and user needs to the new customer journey phases established by our Service Design team.



Clustered these into Themes to focus on as part of the project.



Workshopped with the wider Core Team to prioritise which of these Themes would be best suited to match the brand experience.



Proceeded to ideate and conceptualise what the top 3 prioritised ideas could be like.



Collaborated with our Core Researcher to perform a desirability study centred around these 3 ideas.



Iterated based on the otherwise positive learnings and proceeded to include these into the conceptual work with Brand and DS.

Process

Design Guidance

Once the teams got involved and started updating their respective views and components, we ensured to provide as much support and guidance as possible.

This was done through both hands on work as well as a formal Review Process where designers would book us in to review their pages before going for Development.

🧭

Establishing Web & Visual Guidelines that could be used by all designers and developers alike.

This included creating Breakpoint and Layout guidelines to ensure teams with different views could make the best decisions.

🤝

Defining and supporting with Developer specifications and ways of working to improve Designer x Developer collaboration.

This included working with setting a standard for Ready for Development, such as Design System connectivity.

🔑

Building and reviewing both Web components and views, ensuring these met both Web UX, Accessibility and Brand Standards, without interfering with SEO.

This included creating forums with SEO, Content, Accessibility Experts & the Core group.

🚦

Planning and performing Design Reviews to ensure the updated pages were up to standard and ready for development.

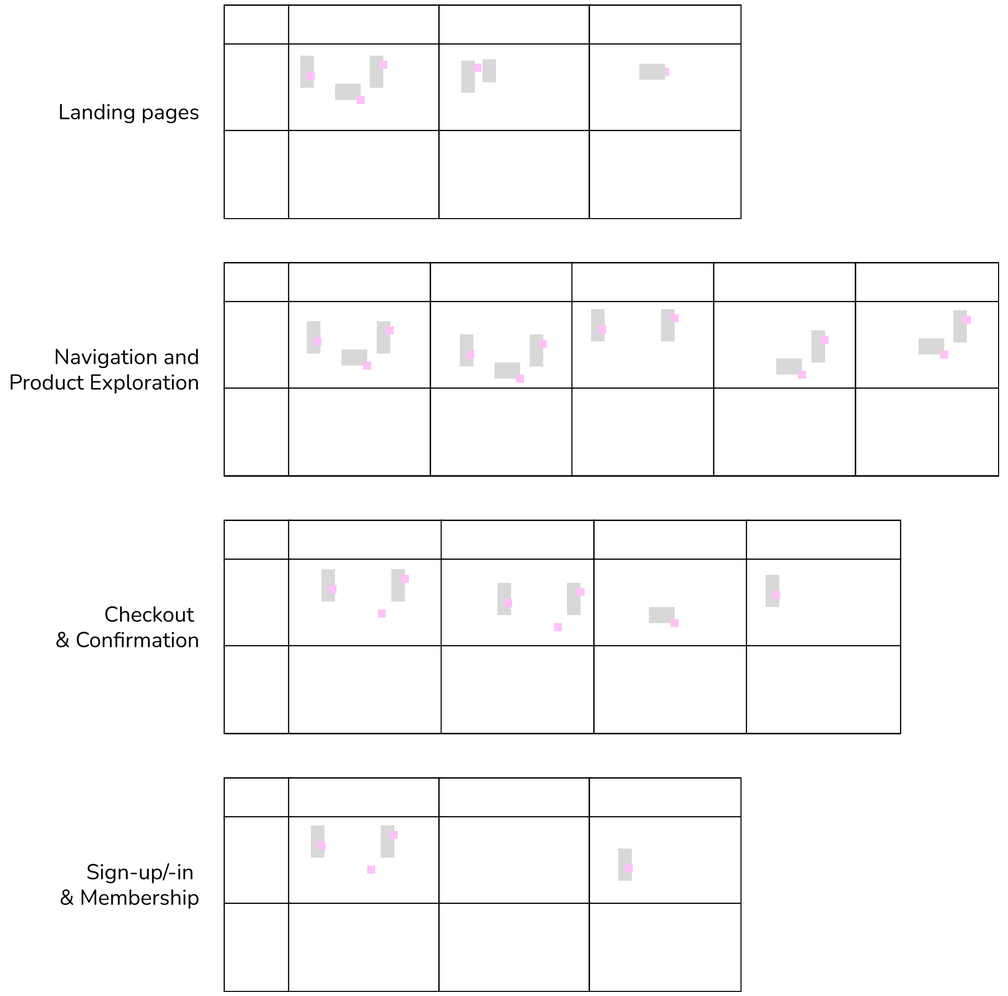
This included taking feedback from teams for us to implement changes across the wider experience as well.

Process

Collaboration & Design QA

A large QA Initiative was set by the development community for both App and Web.
I took the initiative to establish the Design QA, created a *Miro* Board, added a Table for each teams Vertical.

This was used by most teams, dozens of people and documenting ~50 visual issues in 2 weeks.



💡 *This was actually inspired by two designer's QA methods that were being done in isolation from each other.*
I combined these with their consent, and made sure the designers got the recognition for the great contributions they made to the wider process.

These tables were then organised in App, Web and by Team, where anyone was encouraged to grab screen-shots and highlight any visual issues, comparing to the Figma designs as reference.
From here, the owning designer would converse these into Defects.

Deep-Dive: *Entrances*

Discovery

Exploration

Delivery

Discovery

- **Gather insights** from behavioural metrics and formative studies, through desk research or continuous research.
- **Identify, define and prioritise** problems or opportunities from said insights in order to shape Exploration goals.
- **Perform deeper studies** through Surveys or a second round of interviews as need be.

Exploration

- **Ideate collaboratively** to explore in how to solve problems or capitalise on opportunities.
- **Prioritise** proposals based on Business, Tech feasibility and Customer Desirability.
- **Validate** prioritised proposals through **summative studies.**

Delivery

- **Create UI and Interaction specifications** in collaboration with developers.
- **Adhere to standards,** such as Design Systems, Content Guidelines and Accessibility.
- **Follow up on outcomes** and introduce these learnings back into Discovery, repeating the cycle of build, measure, learn.

Departments Discovery

Definition

Problem

Customers tend to exit from Department pages early, causing many to drop off early in the funnel. This meant a fragmented experience, as well as limited discovery for the user.

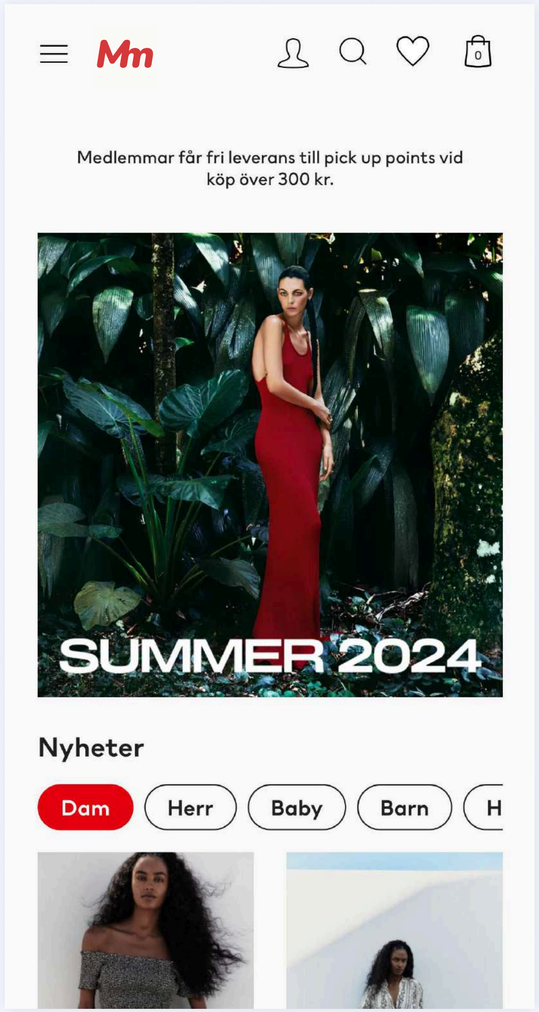
Goal

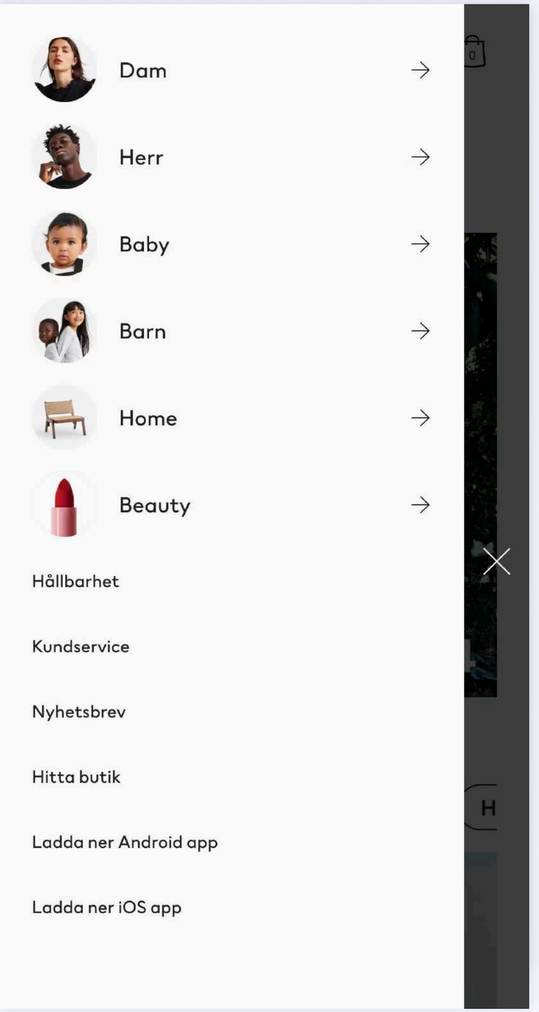
Increase traffic down the funnel, allowing departments to be discovered but also set as the default landing page for returning customers, ensuring more customers would continue down the funnel.

Hypothesis

Making the Index Page the Women's department, but also **exposing the other departments as tabs**, would both focus the start page, while making each department easier to find and segment on, **increasing discovery**.

Old Landing Experience & Department Navigation





On Mobile only way to learn of new Departments was of the in-view Menu, which focused on New Products, or through the Navigation Menu.

Departments Discovery

Research

A lot of the research had already been conducted by our CX Unit and Core Researchers.

Going forward, we would prioritise Summative Research topics to validate between different proposals through Usability and Desirability studies.

Based on existing insights, we concluded that **the landing and department pages had to be easier to explore from.**

Customers overwhelmingly get inspired in social media before entering our store.

Mobile represents about 65% of our web traffic, however Desktop is often still for transactions. This could also indicate potential improvements in our Mobile Web experience.

Web users are often new and unfamiliar with us, while App is used by Members more familiar with our brand.

Customers will often switch between browsing and seeking modes in a single session.

Fashion Customers can be largely divided into two types: Guidance Seekers or Validators. **Our primary target, Fashionistas, are Validators.**

First impressions matter, and landing on a landing page that looks unfocused with unclear navigation can lead to the user bouncing off.



Although our CX Unit had performed most of the foundational research regarding our Target's behaviour, I was still involved in shaping these studies as a consumer of the research, providing questions and considerations.

Departments Exploration

Flows & Info Architecture

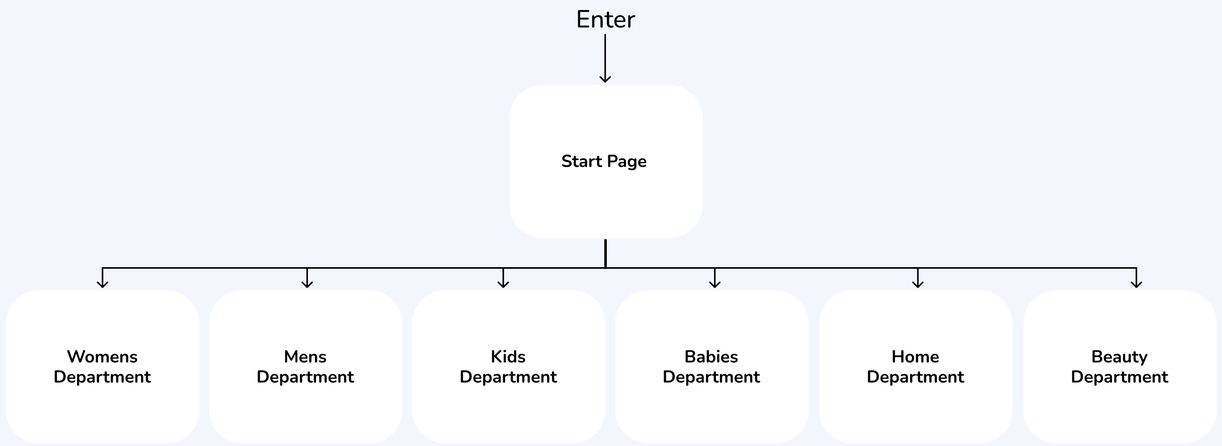
One of our goals was to **simplify the Info Architecture and Site Structure** of the Department pages, which meant consolidating a few pages.

- The Start Page became the Women’s Department.

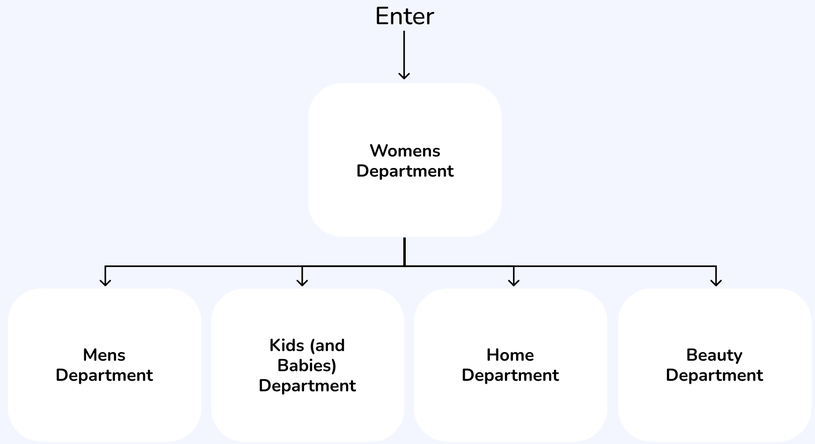
- Kids & Babies were merged into Kids.

This small change had a huge impact in our customer landing experience, ways of working, and SEO.

From



To



Departments Exploration

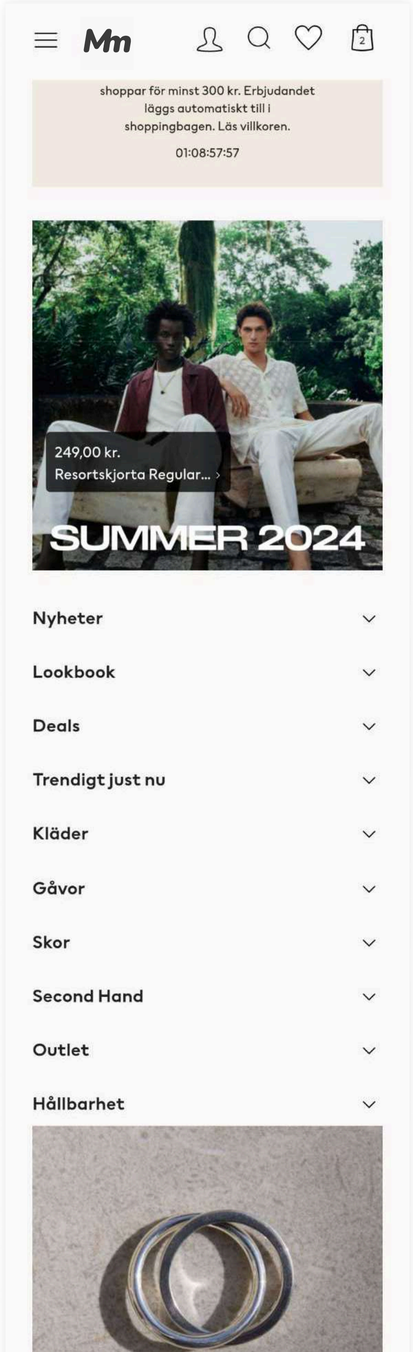
Department Ideation

As part of the **Core UX Exploration**, we prioritised this theme.
The prioritisation was done through an Impact Map with the Core Team and PM's of the Landing and Department Pages, followed by an Ideation Session with the Designers.

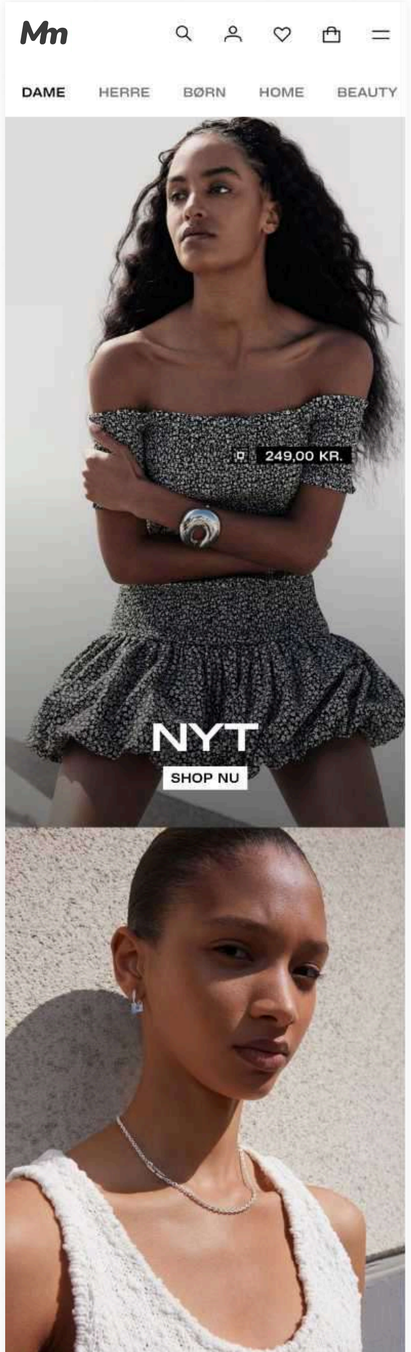
Selected Design

We hypothesised this direction would enable customers to more easily jump between departments when they landed on our start page.

Old Start Page



New Start Page



Departments Exploration

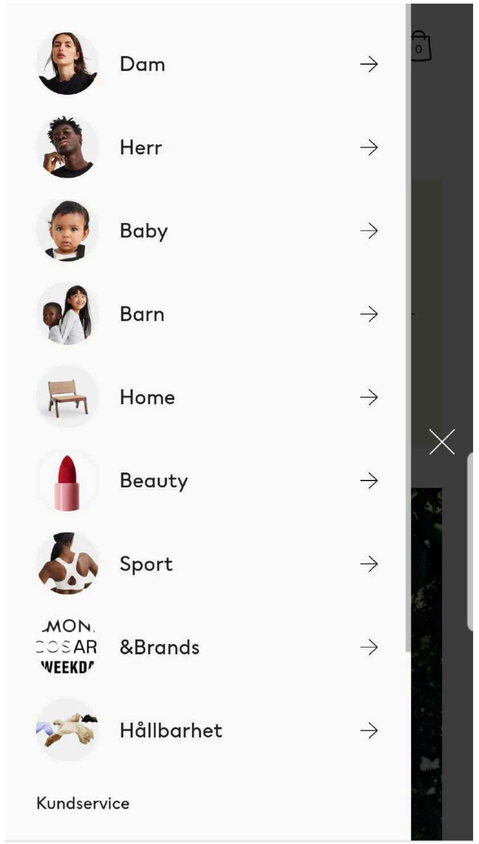
Navigation Ideation

Due to the scope of this study, we needed to include the Primary Navigation as well.

Although this was treated as a separate activity in the study, it was still included to ensure we were't only looking at one side of the experience.

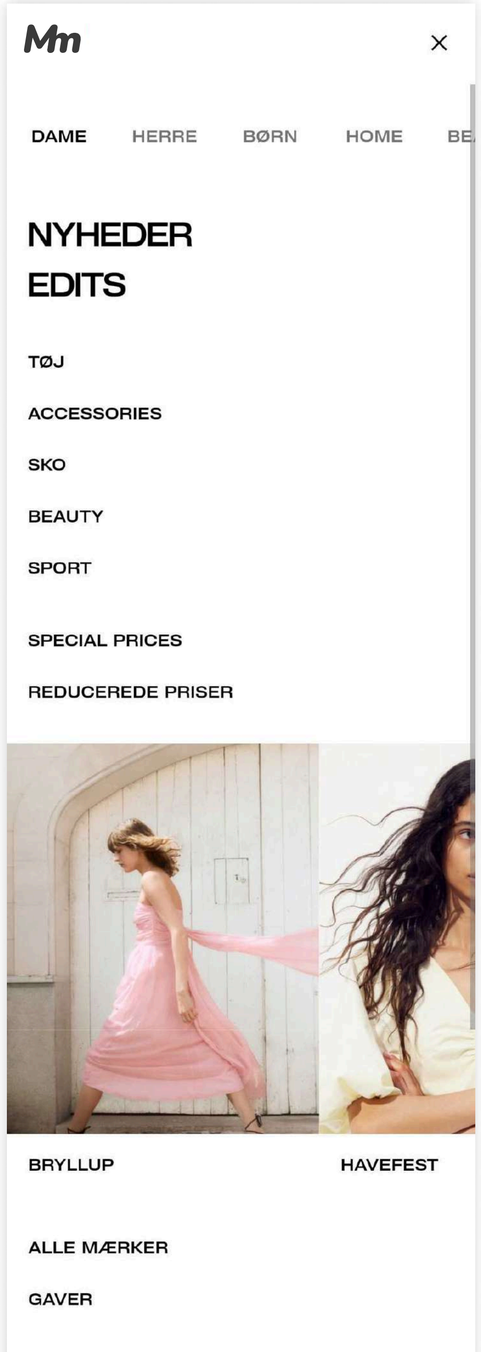
An emphasis on 2nd level navigation was based on the knowledge customers were most often already in their desired department.

Old Primary Navigation



Regardless of where the customer is, the Primary Navigation menu will always start them at the highest level of Department Views, which is often redundant, since the customer wants a more context sensitive list of options, usually 1 level down.

New Primary Navigation

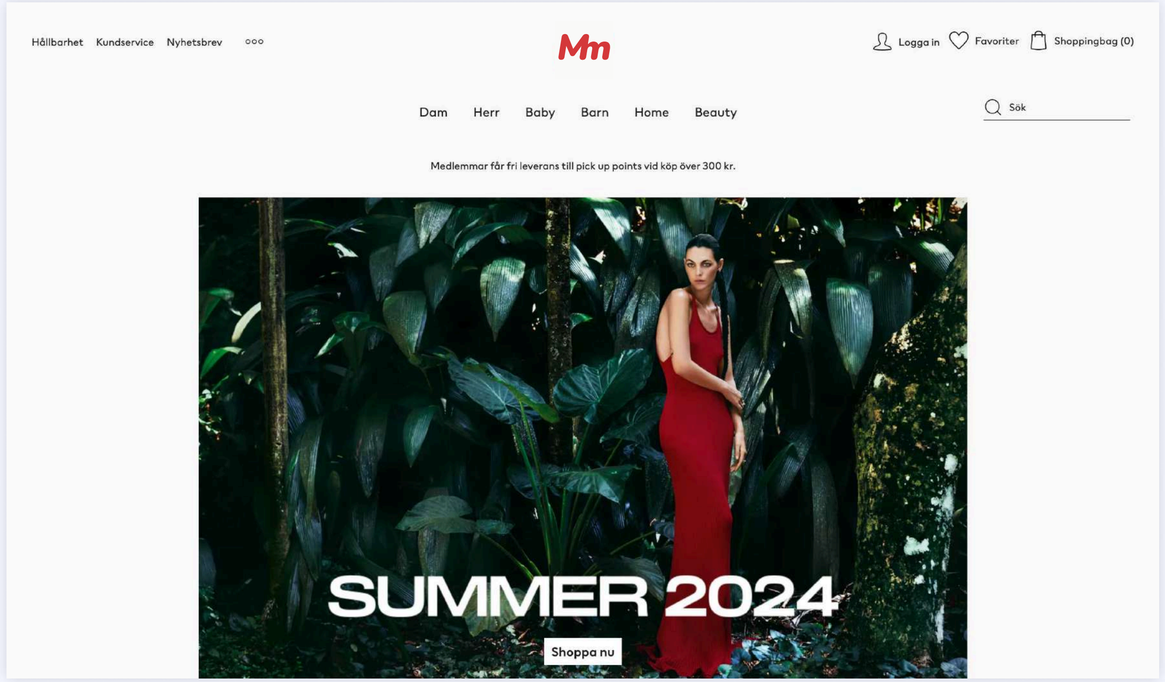


Departments Exploration

Departments - Desktop

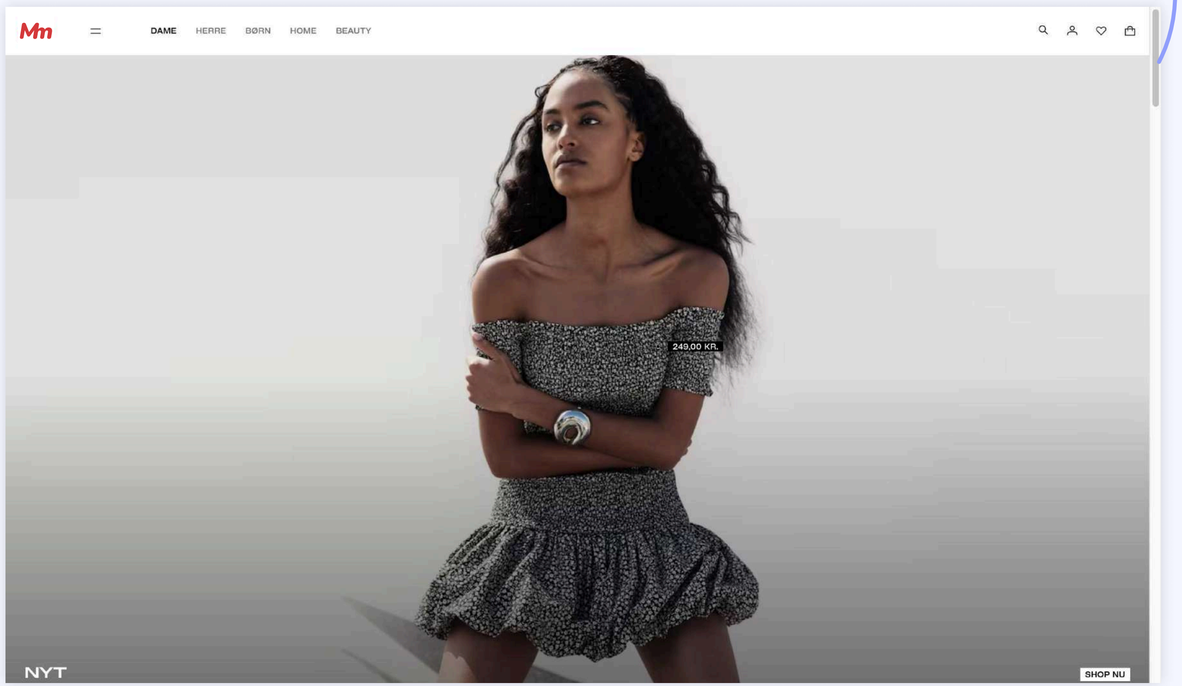
Navigation Icons without supportive text are a usability risk, however these had been texted long before and we were confident they were familiar enough to justify their usage on Desktop.

Old Start Page Desktop



The old Desktop page had a lot more exposed navigation elements, which may be good for ease of access, but for new customers (often using Web) it could be overwhelming.

New Start Page Desktop



On Desktop, the goal was to also expose the departments, but without occupying any vertical real estate, as well as to declutter and thus focus the experience.

We certainly did have issues however with the font tokens on Desktop which cause them to feel disproportionately small on release.

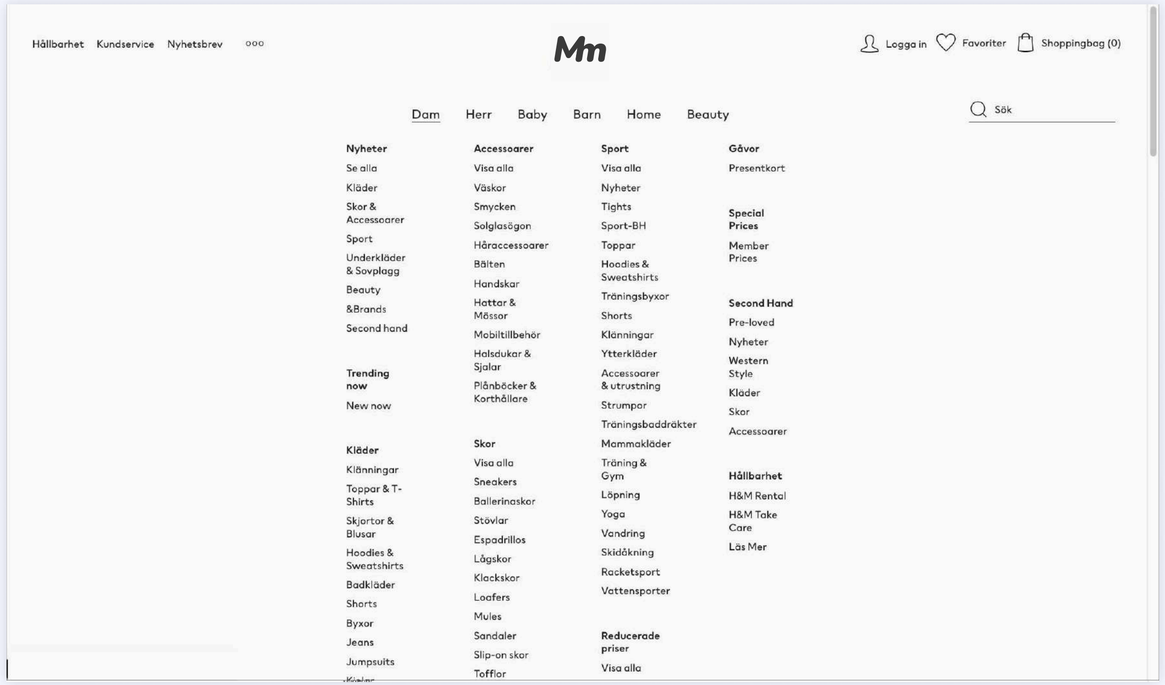
Departments Exploration

Navigation - Desktop

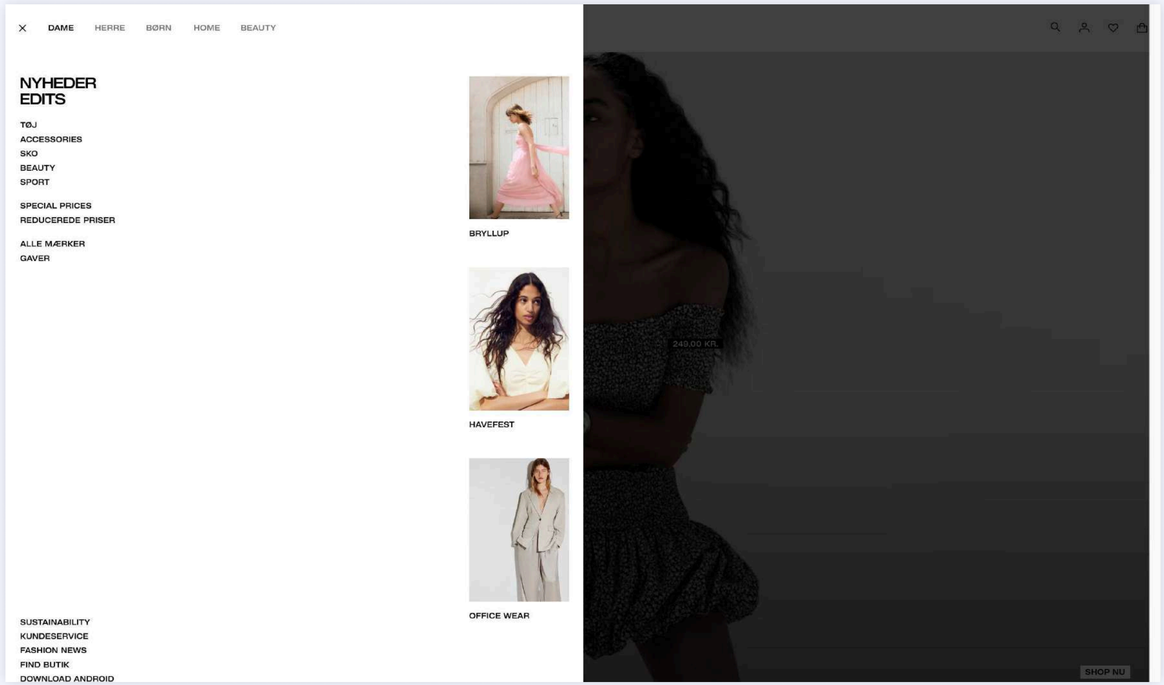
The Departments remained up top, providing a quick way to switch between departments in the meu at any time.

The excessive size of the menu was an unintended consequence of the right-hand tiles being too small during implementation.

Old Navigation Menu Desktop



New Navigation Menu Desktop



The old Desktop site had a hover mega-menu, which had its benefits: it was easy to quickly navigate anywhere from anywhere.
The issue was: it was a LOT of information, and multiple patterns to keep track of on Mobile & Desktop.

Although the new design did hide a lot of navigation behind a hamburger menu or icons, it did help focus the experience in levels (progressive disclosure) and also unified the desktop and mobile navigation patterns (easier to maintain).

Departments Exploration

Usability Study

Study
The Navigation Team and I wanted to validate the Navigation which was also impacted by this change, so we, together with our Core Team Researchers created a Research Plan. The Researchers conducted study and then reported to us the results.

- Type: Qualitative Discoverability Study
- Hypothesis: Users will have no issue navigating to and between departments on the landing or secondary pages.
- Participants: 9 (1 male, 8 females), 21-37 y/o, Region DE, UK and US, Regular Shoppers
- Method: Remote Moderated
- Prototypes: App, Mobile & Desktop, Old and New versions of the start page.

Key Insights

The department navigation was a very intuitive way to move between departments.

Although useful, participants also wanted to quickly view categories once selecting a department.

One participant did highlight they preferred the hover-over effect lacking from the new department navigation design.

Women often navigated to Men’s departments anyway since it was common for them to shop, or at least browse, for their partners.

Since the menu on App was at the bottom, while Web at the top, the experience of navigation was very different.
On Mobile users expected the departments to appear the same in the menu due to their proximity to the navigation tab.

Departments Exploration

Summary

- The **new design** with an exposed department tab was **validated** enough to be worth pursuing.
- **Exposing departments** upfront on Mobile **would make it easier** for new and returning customers to explore.
- **Web and App** would need **fundamentally different** Navigation Menu’s, since the navigation bar and expectation is different between devices.
- **Fewer departments** would reduce complexity, increase presence of existing departments, and **simplify the navigation**.
- The only **key issue** was some customers might **lack the mega menu** on Desktop which displays all categories per department.

With these conclusions, we were ready to proceed confidently into Delivery.





Departments Delivery

Two teams - one experience

This experience was owned by two separate teams in two separate verticals:

- **The Entrances Team** *(which I am in)*, accountable for the Landing Pages and Department Pages.

- **The Navigation Team**, accountable for the Navigation Menu.

However, to the customer, this is **one experience**, and thus, we worked as such.

I was involved in building the Navigation Menus for Web in collaboration with the Navigation Designer to provide support but also ensure that connecting tissue.

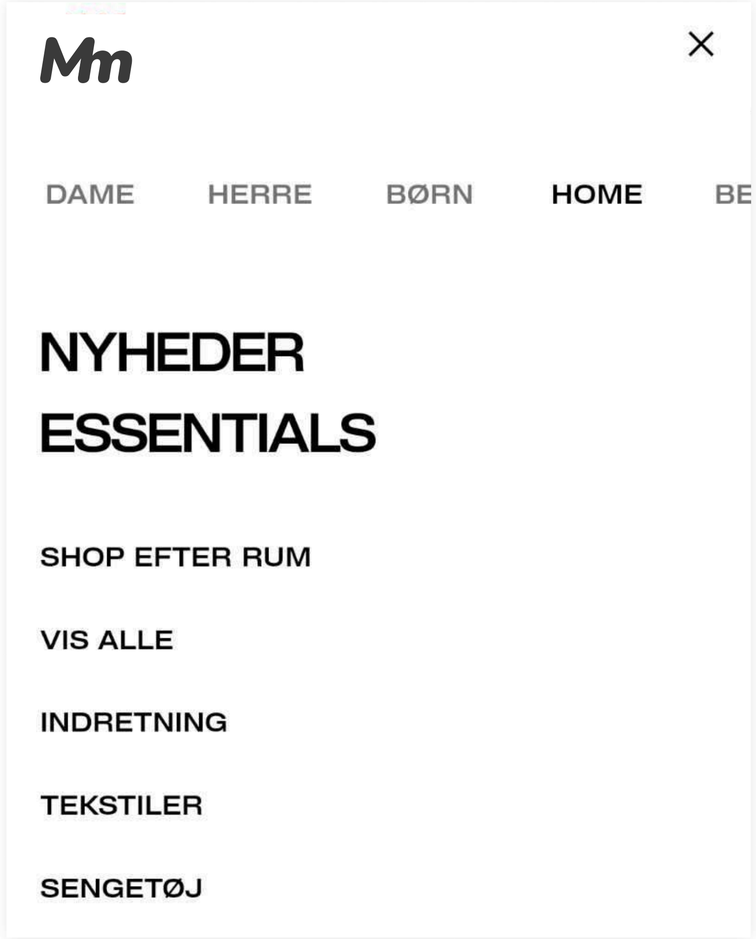
Departments Delivery

Visual Identity

Typography is bigger and bolder font reflected less copy, and tighter voice and tone.

Spacing is adjusted with font size increase, reducing cluttering focusing content.

Media was put on focus, removing most margins and giving more room for visual content.







Departments Exploration

Department & Navigation

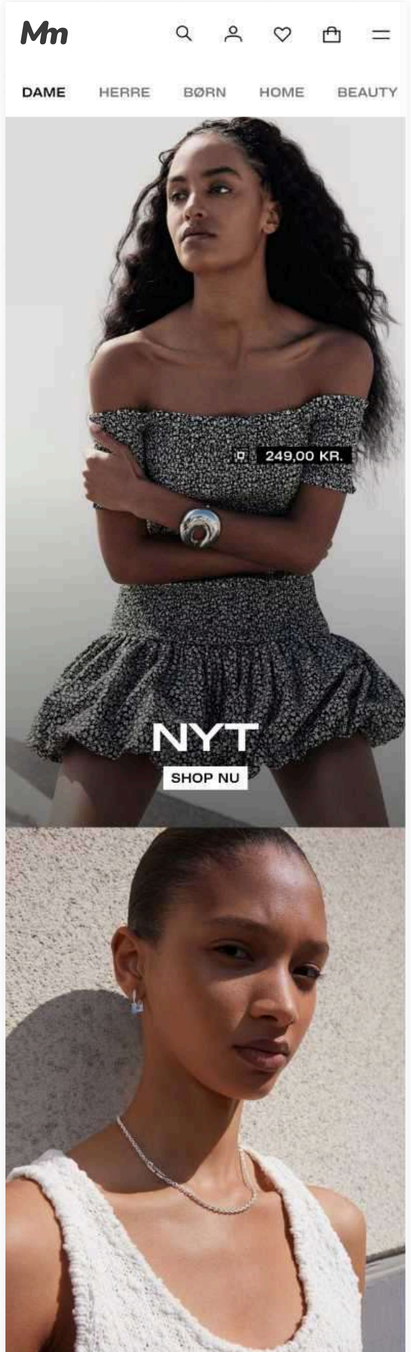
The key goal was to **ensure that departments were out of the way but always accessible.**

We made it work through a **shared Department Navigation Tab.**

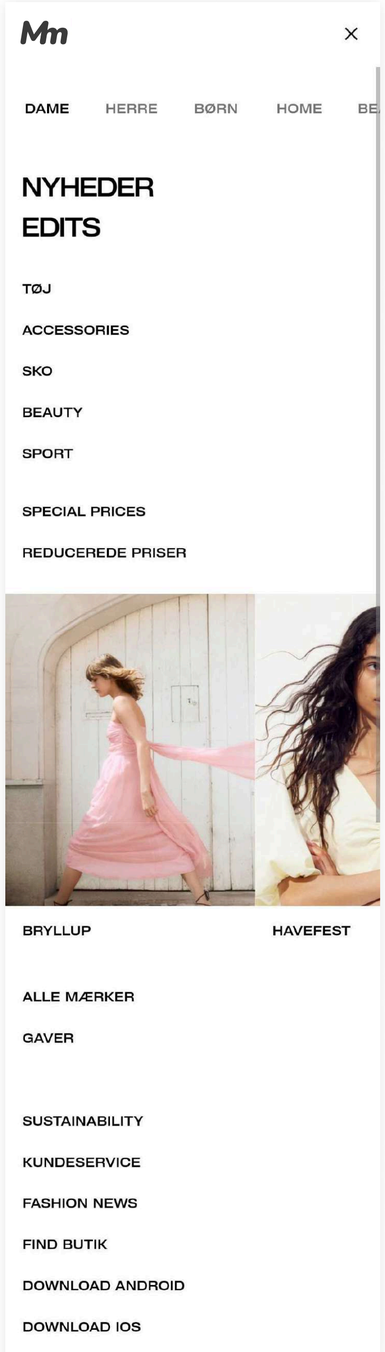
This was **built as a Component**, and re-used in the same way across both views:

- Always in relation to the “Header” on Mobile & Desktop, which would insure a familiar placement.
- Display the active Department at all times in Navigation
- Horizontal swipe if text overflowed with options on Mobile.

Women’s Department



Women’s Categories

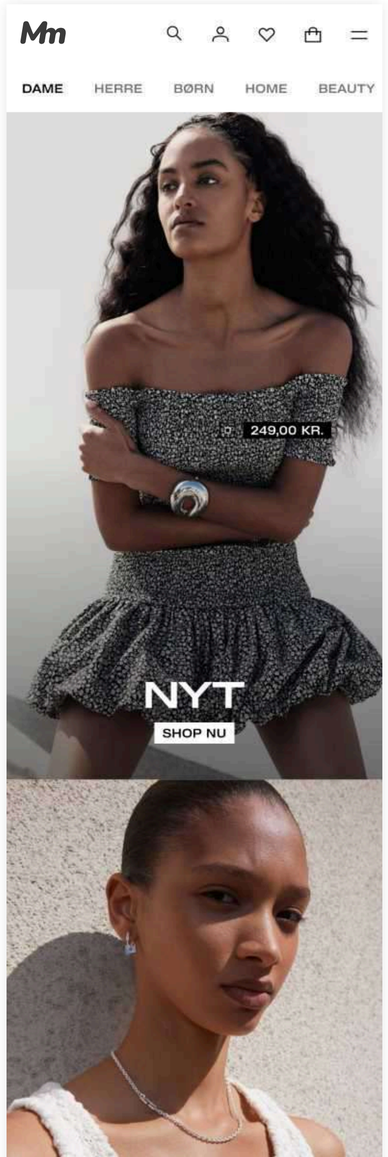


Departments Delivery

Departments

The Women or Men Department would be set automatically if a customer decided to select a gender upon account creation.

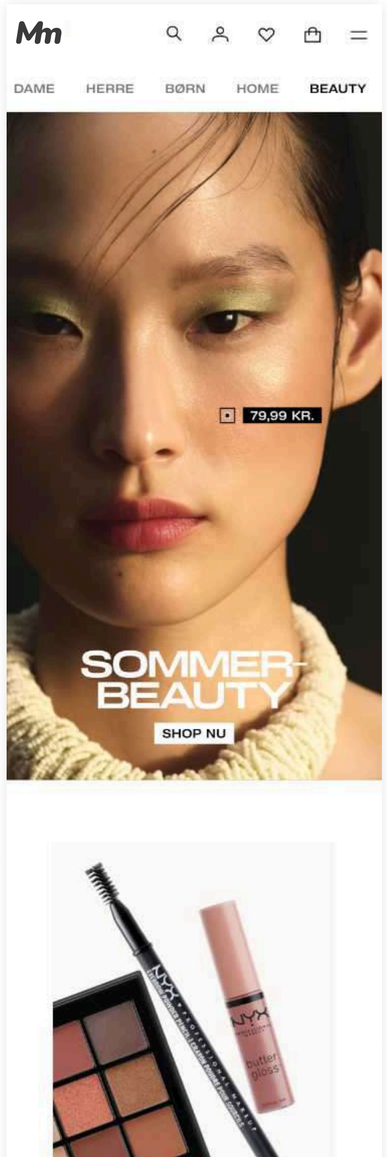
The proximity of the navigation header to the department bar meant users expected it to retain this format when opening the navigation menu.











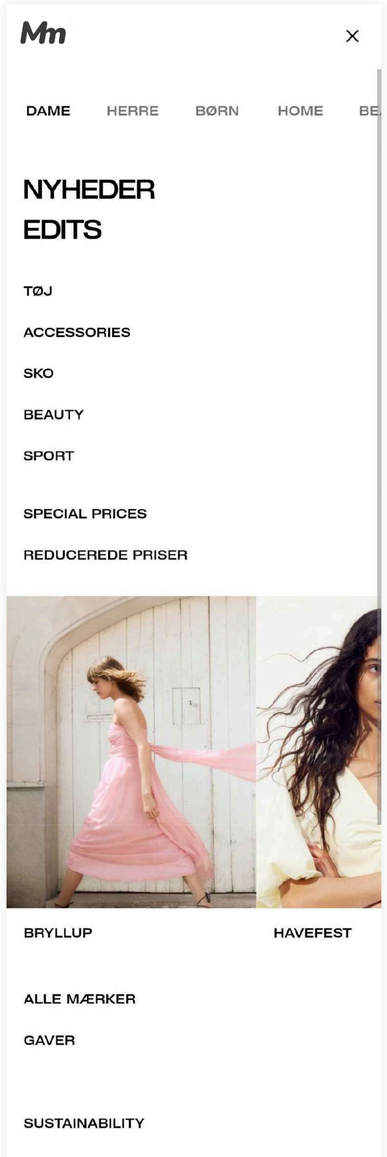
Departments Delivery

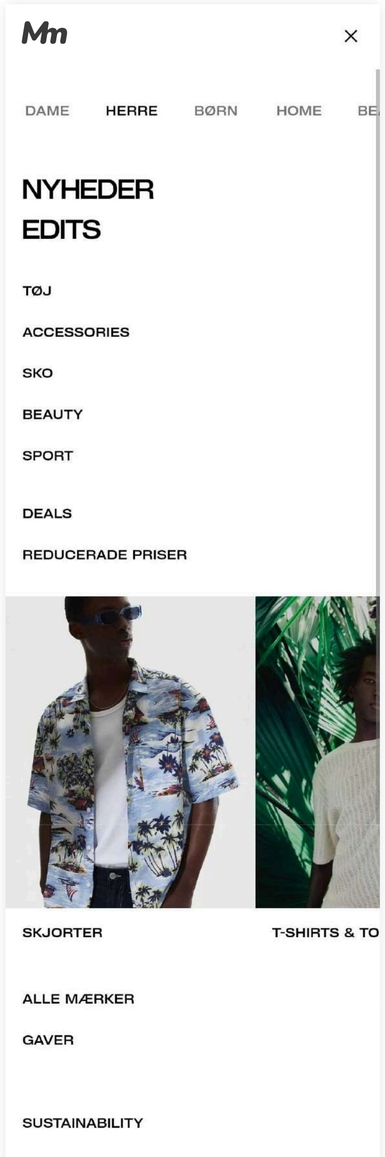
Navigation

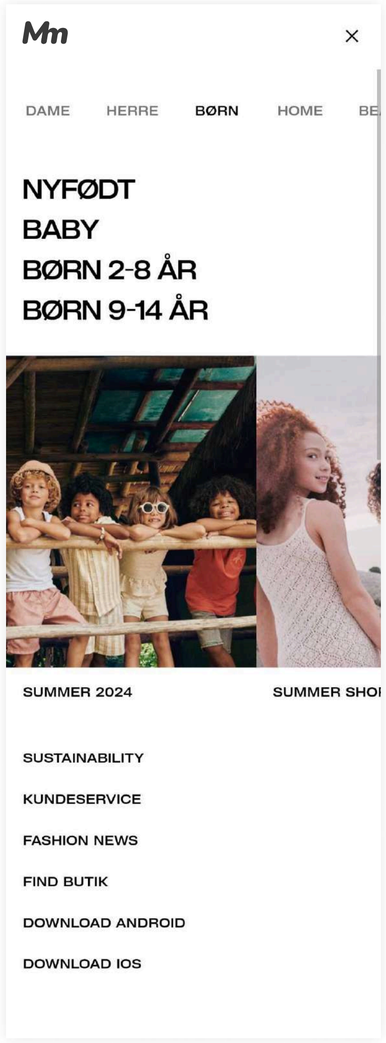
Kids required an extra level for ages, so it differed in overall navigation structure vs other departments, which created quite a different visual layout.

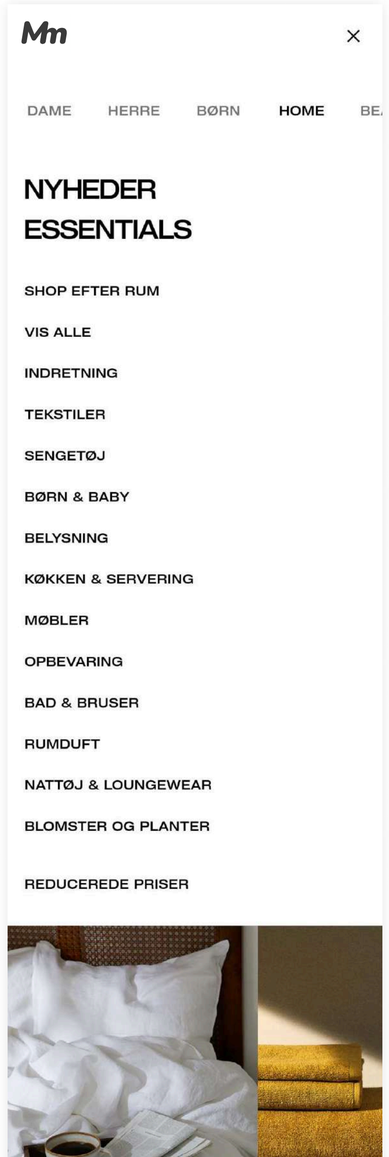
We reused the same department bar component both in the nav menu and header, on both mobile and web, to ensure the efficient use of a component.

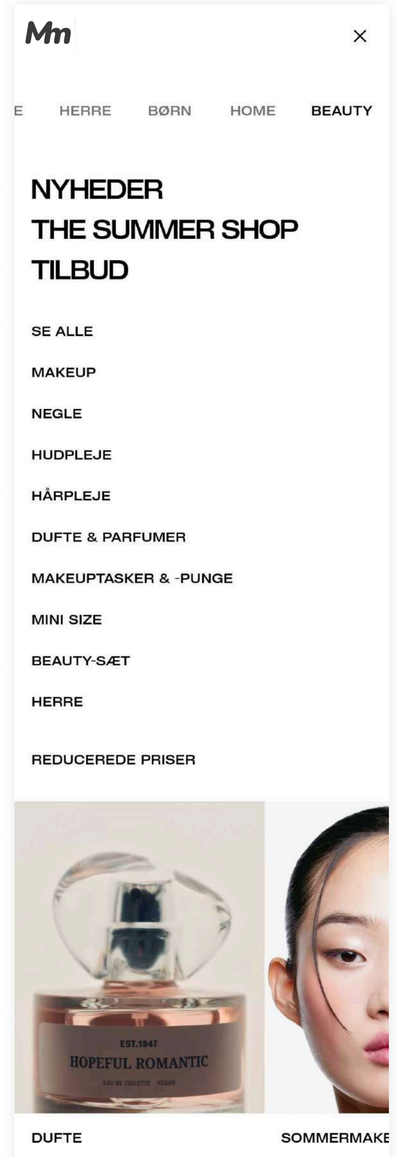
Spacing was one of the challenges with this massive update, and this is one example, as the Departments should align. But this isn't a priority issue.





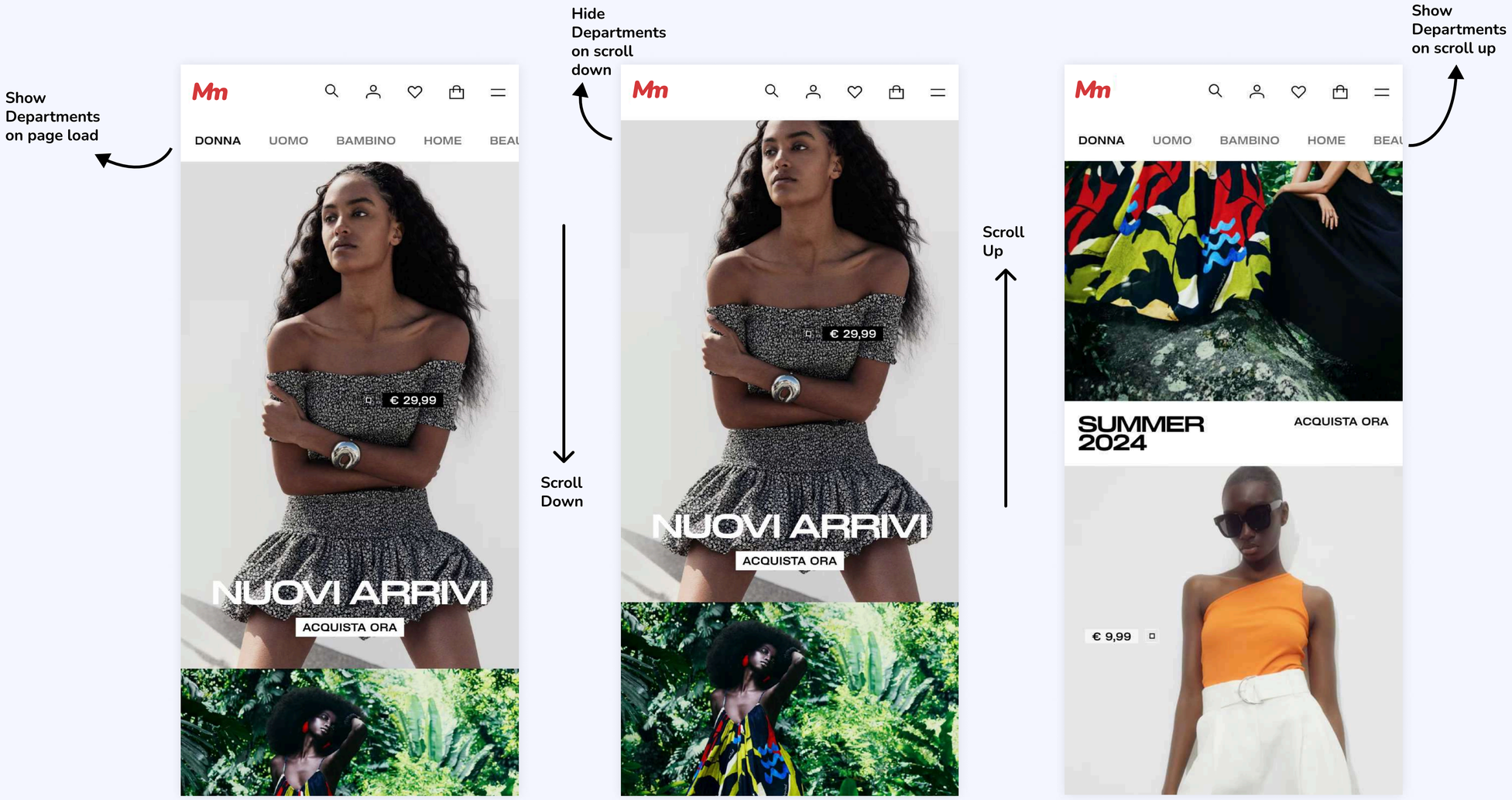






Departments Delivery

Department Interaction



To ensure we maximise vertical real-estate, we hide the Departments on scroll down. We also remove them on other views.

On scroll up, we reveal the departments again, ensuring users can switch departments even though they've left the initial state.

Departments **Conclusion**

Outcomes

Although still early and only two markets as a Pilot, these are very promising signs.

A very important factor is that all the different departments now were having more traffic as we were emphasising their presence on Mobile Web and Apps.

Future Improvements based on learnings

- Department Navigation on other parts of the journey.
- Using Department preferences to shape other recommendations.
- Expanding the Department Tab pattern to be used elsewhere, like with Categories.

Performance

- *vs Last Year May 3rd to May 31st*
- *Landing & Department Pages*

An **increase of ~27% sessions**, from ~330k to ~450k. This could be due to many factors, but such a shift YoY is often due to more than season & marketing.

~14% drop in Single Pages Sessions for Index and Department pages, from ~10% to ~8.5%, indicating more users browsing beyond these.
This is ~11k more sessions that went beyond 1 page.

~**11% drop in Exit Rate for Index & Departments**, from ~15% to ~13%, indicating an increase in users going beyond these.
This is about 9k fewer sessions exiting in 1 month.

~40% increase in page performance, which contributed to an improved experience and SEO ranking.

Conclusion

Impact

Lessons Learned

Impact

- **Increase of Sessions, a drop in Single-Page-Sessions and Exit Rate** ensured an increase of up to ~20k customers per month for two markets would continue down the funnel towards transaction.

- **Business Units were very happy** to have their department more easily discoverable, while also having better content guidelines and UI elements to work with.

- **Cross-area collaboration with Brand and Content was improved**, reducing the time & cost of campaign productions **by half.**

- **Web experience and SEO was improved** thanks to consolidation of department pages and reduction in page loading times, largely thanks to less content on the Index and Department pages.

⚠️ *Although rebrands can often be a long term investment, we could have done more quantification work and gotten more solid insights.*



Lessons Learned

- **Big Projects are very risky:** Learn early and often to de-risk.
- **Include teams earlier in the process:** Committee based design at this scale is harmful for culture and high risk.
- **Up-front navigation helps discovery:** Users will find what they are looking for more easily if it’s visible.

Relevance as a Pleo Staff Designer

- I now have experience in **how to tackle big cross-departmental navigation challenges**, both in process and team coordination.
- I have worked on **how Brand can be better integrated** into product.
- I have a better idea of **how to bring teams together on a greater unified mission**.

